UNIT 4

Hydrosphere

Learning Objectives

- To understand the importance of water
- To learn about the nature, uses and distribution of fresh and salt water
- To understand the relief features of the ocean floor
- To study about the movements of ocean water
- To learn about marine resources and the need for conservation

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Introduction

We know that, our planet Earth consists of **four spheres**. They are the **Lithosphere**, **Atmosphere, Hydrosphere** and **Biosphere**. In the earlier chapters, we have studied about the Lithosphere and Atmosphere. We shall now learn the other two spheres namely the Hydrosphere and the Biosphere.

4.1 Hydrosphere

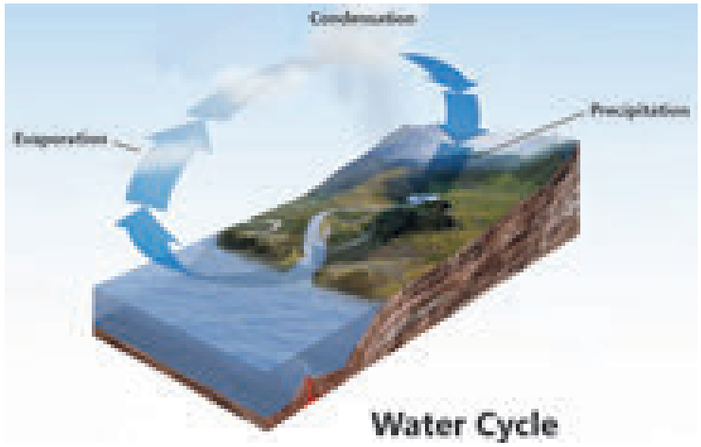
One of the most indispensable natural resources on earth is water. The Earth is also called the **Blue planet**, as it holds water in abundance and thus stands unique among all other planets. Hydrosphere consists of water in various forms found on the earth. Over 97% of the water on the Earth's surface is confined to oceans. Less than 3% of water is held on land as glaciers, ice caps, groundwater, rivers, lakes, and also as the water vapour in air.

4.2 Hydrological Cycle

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The Earth's water is not static. It is always in motion. This continuous movement of water on, above and below the earth's surface is called the Hydrological Cycle. The **three major processes** involved in the water cycle are **evaporation, condensation and precipitation**. Water changes its form constantly i.e. Ice, water and water vapour. This process happens in the blink of an eye or even over millions of years.

Water resources of the Earth can be broadly divided into **fresh water** and **salt water.**



Water Cycle

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